

I decided to make a website for my job. This way, I could experiment more with coding, especially because I want to create an order screen for my job. I also see this project as another opportunity to dive into more research methods again.

Interview

I first conducted an interview with my bosses at Ichi to understand their preferences and needs for the website. From this interview, I identified the following key points:

- * **Alignment with social media:** the website should reflect the aesthetic of their current Instagram posts. Clean and simple, but with pops of color to make the products stand out. For example, bright green is often used to highlight matcha products, while backgrounds remain neutral (white, grey, black). Captions on their posts are usually bold and inviting, which should also be reflected in the tone of the website.

- * **Style preferences:** my boss preferred a minimalistic and modern look that fits their product offering (desserts, matcha, coffee), but he was open to new ideas. However his wife, who co-manages the café, often leans toward a cuter, cozier aesthetic. This created a bit of uncertainty about the final visual direction, but they were open to seeing both styles.

- * **Target audience:** the main audience for Ichi is people aged 15-25, as reflected in their social media strategy which follows online trends, especially on TikTok and Instagram. However, due to the popularity of matcha and coffee, people aged 25+ also visit regularly.

- * **Functional requirements:** the website doesn't need complex features. My boss emphasized the importance of keeping the site simple, clear and user-friendly, focused on showing the menu, contact information and opening hours. He did not want hidden features or too many extras.

Based on these insights, I aimed to create a simple website that includes the most important functions to represent Ichi effectively. I wanted to explore a fitting visual style, which could either lean toward a cosy and cute aesthetic or a more simplistic and modern one. I planned to user-test the site with a younger demographic, specifically people aged 15-25 who enjoy visiting cafés and matcha- or coffee bars.

Even though my boss advised against adding too many extras or hidden features, I suggested implementing a feature where customers could place online orders for desserts or drinks. He agreed that this would be a good and fun addition to the site.

Competitive Research

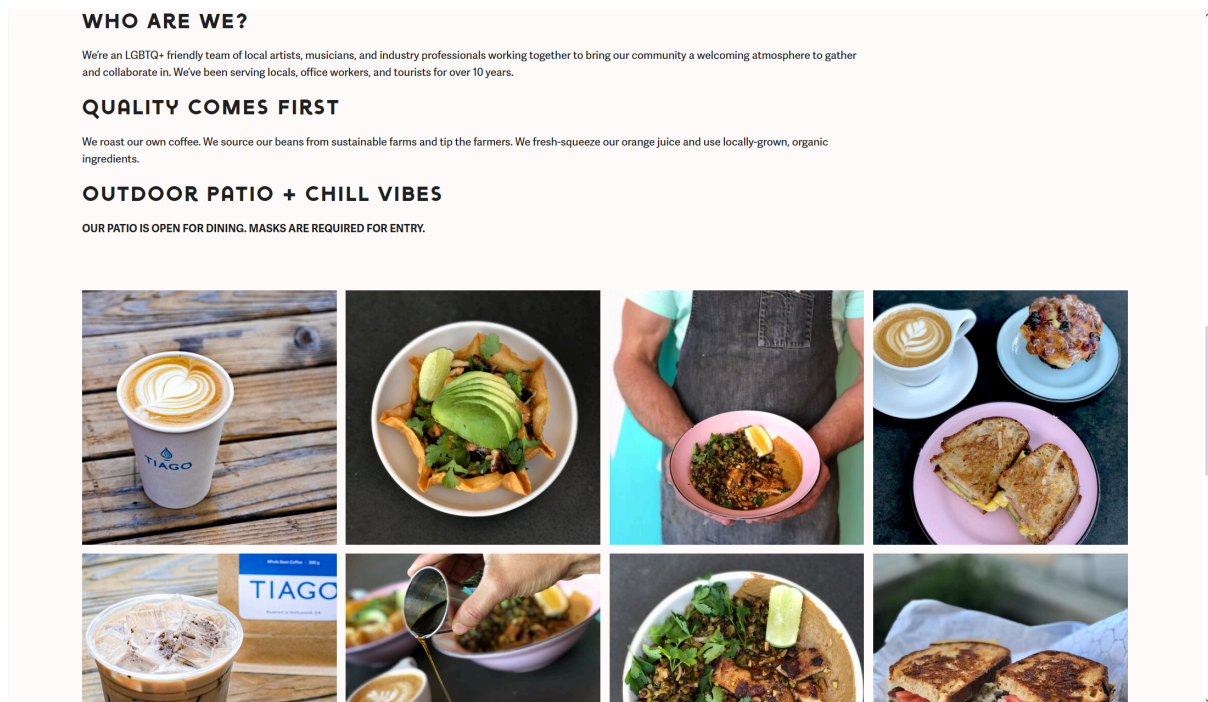
I wanted to conduct competitive research to find inspiration for what a café would typically need in a website, as well as to gather general ideas for design and functionality. I came across a website that featured various café websites and took note of some important elements that contribute to a strong and effective café site.

- * The layout should be clean and easy to navigate.
- * The content should be well-written and engaging, clearly highlighting the café's unique features and what sets it apart.
- * Photography should reflect the overall vibe of the café and showcase the appeal of the food and drinks.
- * Most importantly, the website should stay focused on its main goal(s): helping the visitor, whether that means providing clear information, easy navigation or enticing visuals.

[Source by **SiteBuilderReport**]

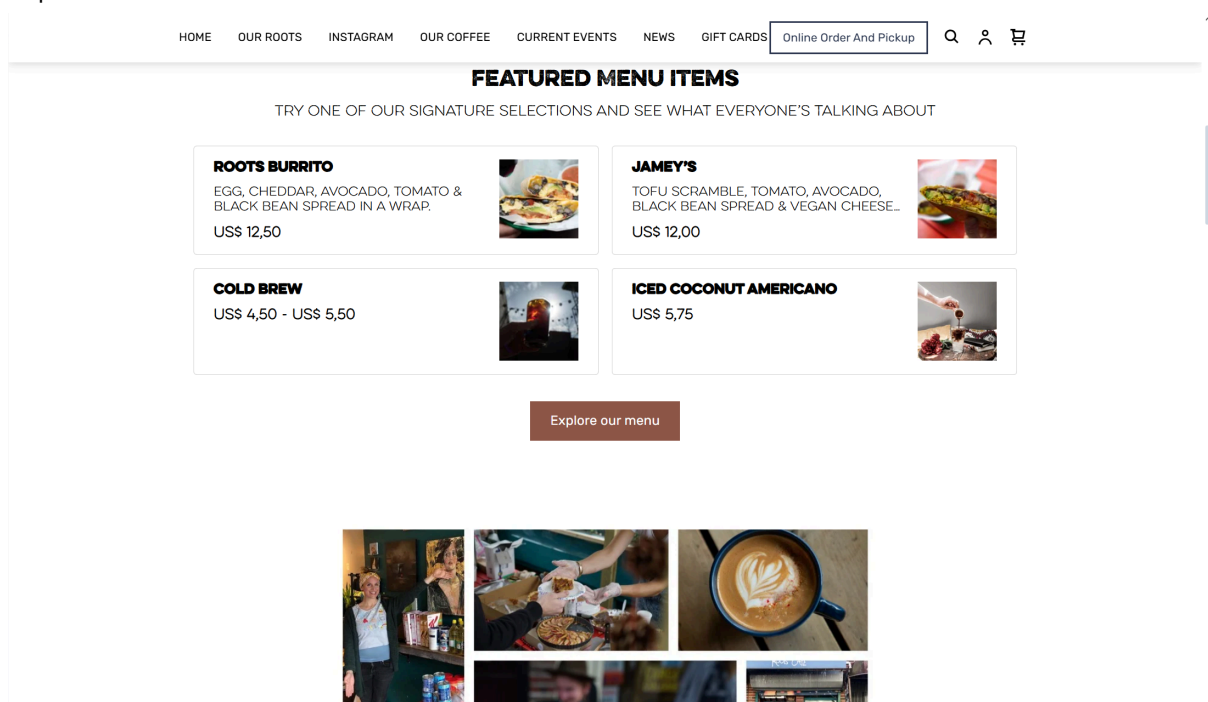
With the bullet points mentioned above, I picked out four different sites I liked and compared them to each other. Below are some examples of points I wanted to implement on the Ichi site as well, along with a screenshot of the café sites I used as examples.

* (Big) pictures of their food and drinks to make their products stand out.



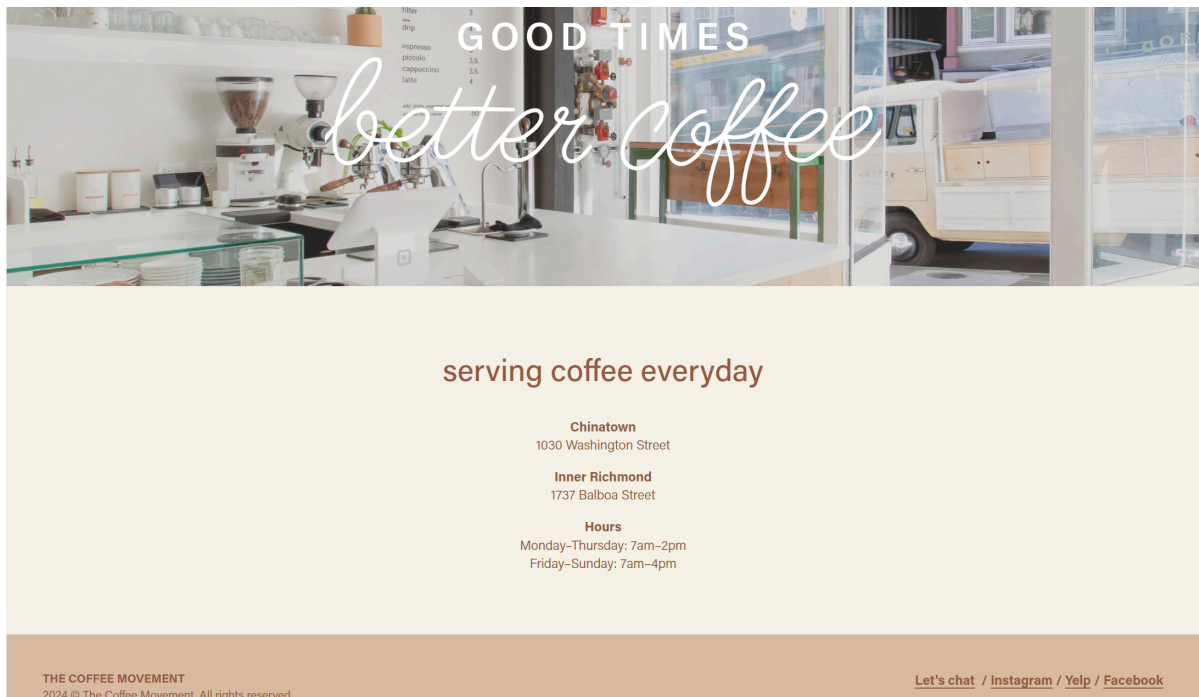
[Source by **Tiago Coffee**]

* Visually showing items from the menu again on the site to encourage visitors to explore the full menu.



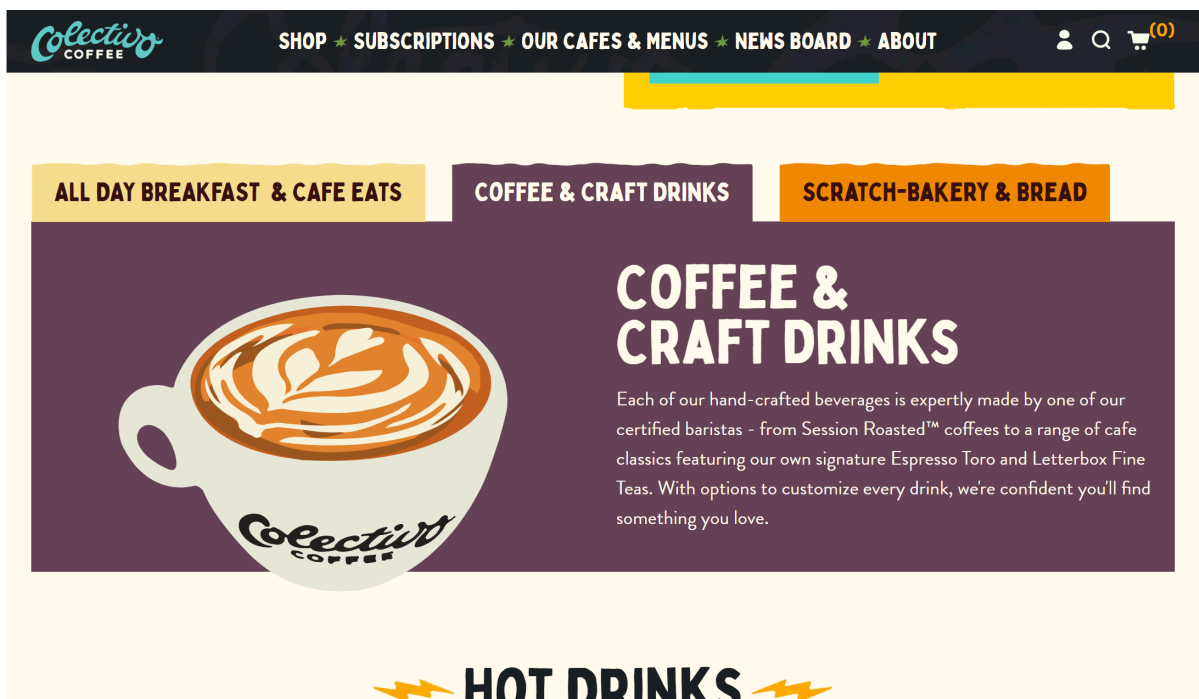
[Source by **Roots Cafe Brooklyn**]

* Mentioning their most important information on the site (address, contact and socials) using a clear and simple layout, so it's easy for customers to find.



[Source by **The Coffee Movement**]

* Giving the site a personal touch through brand-specific colors, symbols or aesthetics to make it more memorable.



[Source by **Colectivo Coffee**]

Logo

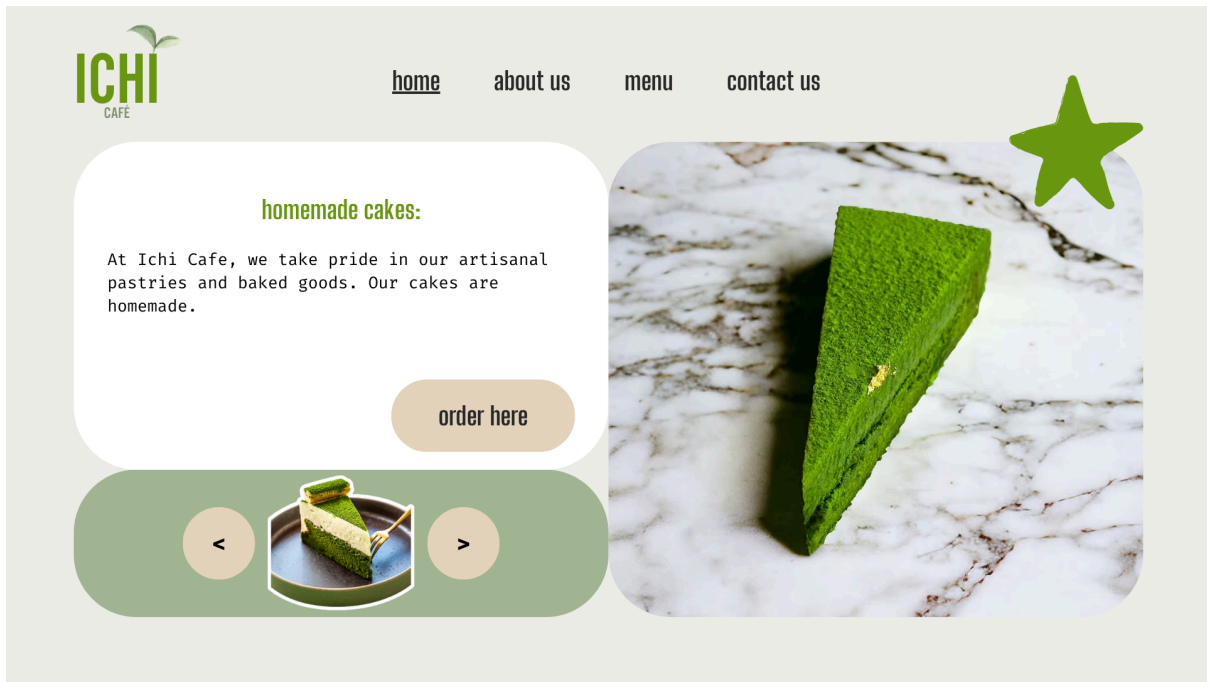
Because Ichi already had a logo, I chose to stick with their simplistic style by using a clean font like "Alternate Gothic N2", but added a touch of green and a leaf element to the "i" to make it look like the leaf is growing out of the letter. This design choice emphasizes the meaning of "Ichi" and connects it to their key ingredient, matcha (made from tea leaves). "Ichi" means "one" in Japanese, symbolizing being number one. Growth is essential to reaching that goal, which is represented by the growing leaf.



Prototype

Because I only had two weeks and my bosses wouldn't have time for multiple meetings, I started with a general homepage layout in a cute and cosy style. I kept it simplistic, but added a personal touch using beige tones and light green to emphasize matcha, Ichi's key product. I included a large dessert photo, a short description linking Ichi to baked goods and a dessert bar where customers can scroll through items as a preview of the full menu. To enhance the cute feel, I added green stickers to highlight the matcha and used rounded blocks and bars for a softer look.

For fonts, I used "Big Shoulders Display" for links, buttons and titles, and "Fira Code" for the main text. Both simple but distinct. This layout was intended to preview the design and get initial feedback from my bosses.



[FEEDBACK 1 HIGHLIGHTS]

My boss liked the overall design, but gave some key points for improvement.

[WHAT HE LIKED]

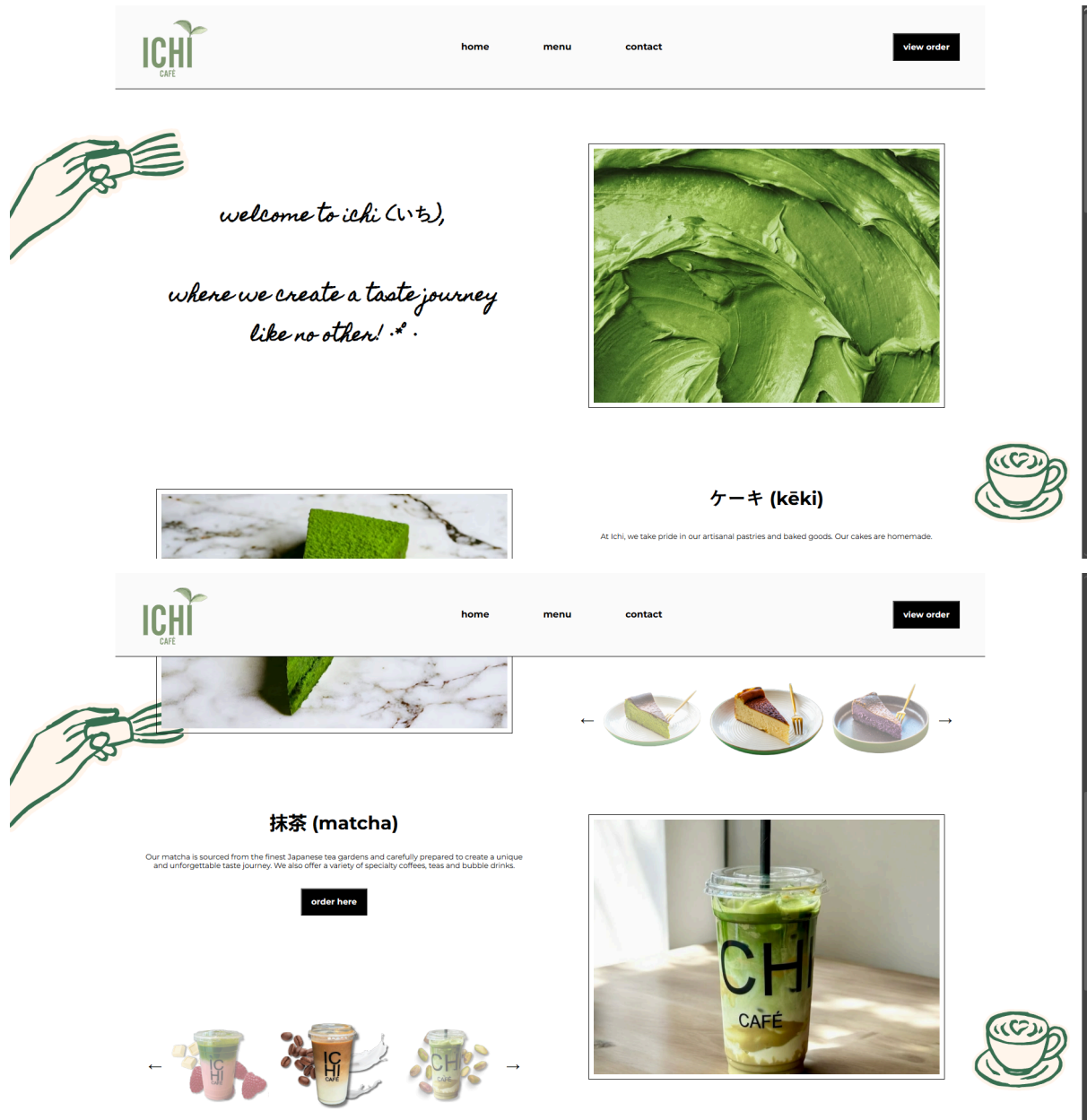
- * The simplicity of the design.
- * The use of separate blocks and bars instead of a single long page: it made the site more fun in his opinion.
- * The small preview of Ichi's menu items.

[WHAT HE WANTED CHANGED]

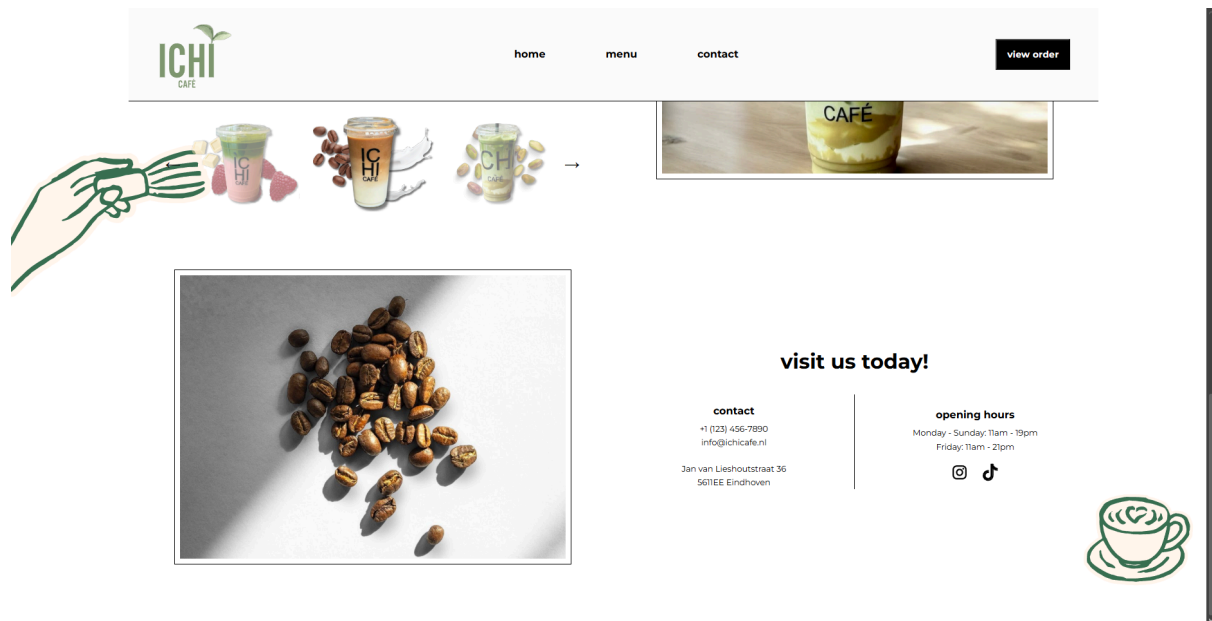
- * He changed his mind about the cute and cosy vibe and preferred a more modern and simplistic style.
- * He wanted a clearer preview of multiple menu items, not just one in the bar.
- * He found the about us page unnecessary. A clear description on the homepage and a contact page would be enough, alongside the menu page.

I decided to keep the layout, but adjusted the color palette, shapes and typography to simplify it as much as possible. I used black and white as the primary colors and relied on the product photos to maintain a cozy atmosphere through their bright colors. I added more items to the preview bar and removed the rounded shapes to create a cleaner, more modern style. To make the website feel modern and minimalist while still retaining a touch of cuteness, I added two green matcha-related images in the background and changed the font of important text to a handwritten style. This way, the website looks modern while still feeling warm and cozy.

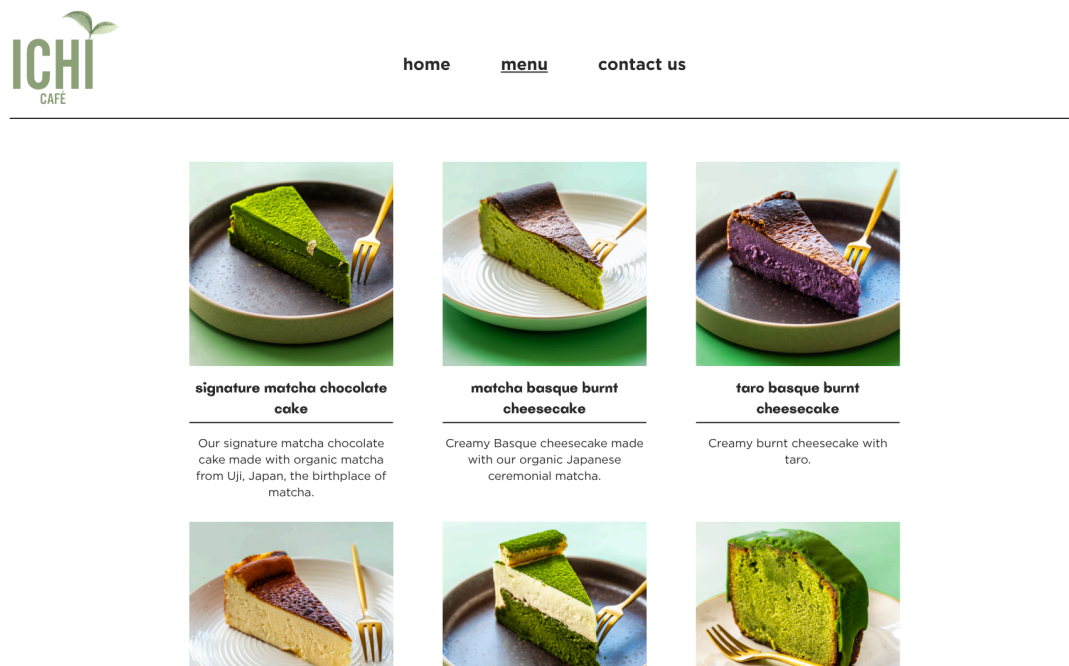
For the fonts, I still chose simplicity, but made important text stand out by using "Homemade Apple", a handwritten cursive font that gives off a cute and cozy vibe. For the body text, I kept a simple font to maintain readability and a clean appearance.



With this style in mind, I completed the entire homepage by also adding a section at the bottom with different drinks and their information. This section includes the telephone number, email address, address, opening hours and links to Ichi's social media.

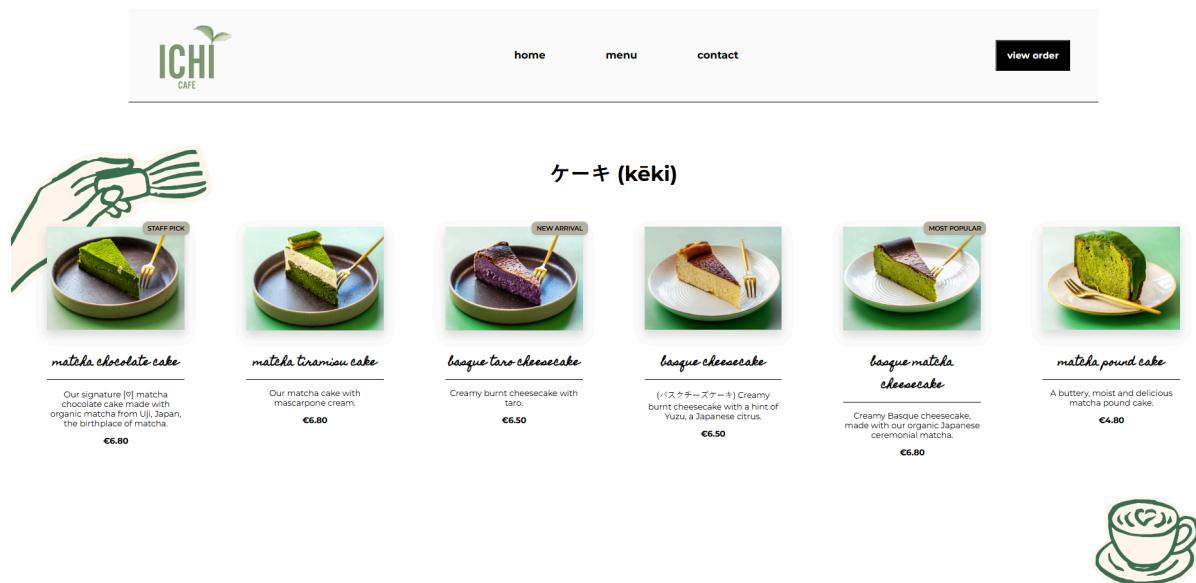


Last but not least, I made the menu page. I used square pictures, with the name of the product and a short description.



[FEEDBACK 2 HIGHLIGHTS]

I showed my prototype to my boss using the preferred style and he seemed very happy with it. He reviewed the homepage and didn't see any flaws, but suggested that the menu page could include additional information, like Ichi's recommended products. This would make the site feel more personal and help customers choose a dessert. I decided to add a simple, small bar to some products and pictures to highlight additional information about certain items. Even though he still needs to take proper pictures of the drinks, he mentioned that creating separate tabs for desserts and drinks in the future could be handy.



Coding

To explore LO2 more deeply in this project, I created several key code snippets that demonstrate my understanding. I built my website using HTML, CSS and JavaScript, and documented my progress and updates on GitLab.

Want to view Ichi's website made by me? Click [here](#).